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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

AI firms threaten to shun Illinois

Say state must weaken its privacy law, one of the country's toughest

By John Lippert and R. Christian Smith
Chicago Tribune

Artificial intelligence companies are threatening to shun Illinois and build their most advanced data centers in Wisconsin and Indiana if the state doesn't dilute its privacy law, the toughest in the country.

Lots of Illinoisans won't be running to their defense.

Unions, even as they clamor for construction work, worry that artificial intelligence will devour far more jobs than it creates. Environmentalists want tighter controls on data center electricity use and noise. Suburbanites don't want to sacrifice their quiet streets.

Meanwhile, Brad Tietz, state policy director for the Data Center Coalition, is seeking to recast the entire debate by issuing a blunt warning.

"You're seeing billions of dollars of investment that Illinois is just not even in the running for," said Tietz, whose Virginia-based lobbying group includes Google, Microsoft and Meta.

Exhibit A is the \$26 billion that Amazon is spending on a fleet of data centers near South Bend, Indiana. These behemoths, known as AI data centers or hyperscalers, don't just store information like traditional data centers. They mine it around the clock to train their algorithms to mimic and perhaps surpass human intelligence. Illinois will miss out on this momentous potential, data operators say, if it clings too tightly to its Biometric Information Privacy Act, which the General Assembly passed by a unanimous vote in 2008.

It's the only state law in the U.S. that allows people to sue and recover damages for the misuse of their biometric profile, which is unique to each individual and cannot be changed. As they try to defend it, Illinois trial lawyers will first have to win over the state's fractious Democratic Party, said Hugh O'Hara, executive director

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A mural by artist Felix Maldonado of the the Jackson 5, from Gary, along Broadway in downtown Gary on Wednesday. E.JASON WAMBSGANS/TRIBUNE

Gary's grand vision

The long-beleaguered Northwest Indiana city is serious about the Bears. Are the Bears serious about putting a stadium there?

By Andrew Carter | Chicago Tribune

On clear days the Chicago skyline is visible from Miller Beach in Gary, the skyscrapers rising above the horizon 25 miles across Lake Michigan. An enduring wall of gray clouds often obscures the view in winter, though, and on a recent February morning ice covered the dunes and the beach and extended well into the lake, small waves frozen atop each other near the shore.

Occasionally wet-suited surfers arrived in pursuit of waves that had yet to freeze, and others came to walk out onto the shelf ice. Don Ploh, who manages Gary's parks, chases people off the ice just about every day. Until recently that was the extent of wintertime activity along the lakefront in Gary.

Now, though, it's a place of aspiration for city leaders. A place to come and imagine possibilities.

To picture a grand if improbable vision: that of a new Chicago Bears stadium along the beach.

There is a plan, however rough or premature. However fantastical or far-fetched. There is a plan, with a Bears stadium somewhere near Miller Beach, with retail, restaurants and places of gathering: a year-round, multipurpose attraction near Indiana Dunes National Park, amid the hiking trails and kayaking spots and not far from city streets full of so much amassed heartbreak and neglect.

That it is a possibility at all, however remote and unlikely, has inspired an uncommon belief in this long-beleaguered city. Could it be Gary's time after so many years of sorrow? Or is this nothing but a cruel dangling of possibility for a place so accustomed to loss and false hope? A group of city leaders, intent on changing Gary's image, believe in their chances. The faith seems genuine.

Gary has gone all in on the Bears. But are the Bears serious about Gary?

"I think it's going to be real nice on 'Monday Night Football,' with the aerial shots," Carla Morgan, the city of Gary's lead attorney, said of the lakefront site while she pulled into a parking lot just behind the dunes. She spoke as

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Illinois 9th District race tests long Jewish legacy



Incoming U.S. Rep. Jan Schakowsky is the center of attention on Nov. 13, 1998, as she and the new representatives gather on the steps of the U.S. Capitol in Washington for a formal picture. PETE SOUZA/TRIBUNE

CONGRESSIONAL RACES: Top candidates for the U.S. House in Illinois' 2nd, 4th, 7th, 8th and 9th districts for the 2026 election. **Page 4**

VOTER GUIDE: Voters will decide their party's nominees for races at the federal and state levels during the March 17 primary election. **Page 6**

15 Dems in primary race to succeed retiring Schakowsky

By Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

For nearly eight decades, Illinois' 9th Congressional District has been a Democratic stronghold with an almost unbroken tradition of Jewish representation — a political lineage stretching back to the aftermath of World War II and shaped by generations of voters clustered around historically Jewish suburbs and neighborhoods.

That history now collides with a changing district and a crowded, high-stakes Democratic Party field vying to succeed longtime U.S. Rep. Jan Schakowsky, who will retire after 28 years in Congress. The 15-candidate primary race has become a proxy battle involving party divisions, faith, identity and foreign policy,

testing whether old assumptions about who represents the district — and how — still apply.

Once anchored more squarely by neighborhoods such as West Rogers Park and suburbs such as Evanston and Skokie, the district has been redrawn to extend from Chicago's North Side to far-flung suburbs such as Crystal Lake, along with its core on the North Shore. And while Jewish voters remain influential, demographic shifts and generational change have altered the district's once-reliable politics.

At the center of that tension are two Jewish candidates, state Sen. Laura Fine and Evanston Mayor Daniel Biss, who lead the field in terms of campaign cash entering 2026. Their rivalry has drawn national attention in part because of the role of the American Israel Public Affairs Committee, or AIPAC, and broader divisions within the Democratic Party over

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INSIDE



APPHOTOS

A wild ride

The Seahawks' Sam Darnold has overcome doubters. The Patriots' Drake Maye has lived up to the hype. Only one will be Super Bowl champion. **Chicago Sports**

CHICAGO'S CANDYLAND:

A Rogers Park house was an HGTV "Ugliest House in America" finalist. But it's anything but. **A+E**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 31 Low 22

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 20

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